

Let's Appeal

Module 0: Start Here

Read Your Denial Letter Like a Map

Free Edition

Getting a denial letter feels like a door slamming shut. It isn't. It's actually the first page of instructions for how to open it back up.

This guide has one job: help you find your letter, and get comfortable finding the parts of it that matter. Everything you do to challenge a denial starts with this same letter, so the more comfortable you get with it now, the easier every next step will be.

Why fighting is worth your time

Before we go any further, you should know something almost nobody hears from their insurance company: filing an appeal is often the single most effective thing you can do about a denied claim, and most people never do it.

A few numbers from the last several years of federal and independent research:

- On plans sold through HealthCare.gov, insurers denied roughly 19% of in-network claims in a recent year, and about 37% of out-of-network claims.
- Of all those denied claims, fewer than 1% are ever appealed.
- When people do appeal internally, a meaningful share succeed. And when denials go to independent external review, reviewers overturn a substantial share of decisions in the patient's favor.
- In one federal survey, 69% of people who got a denial didn't know they could appeal. Another 86% didn't know what government agency to contact when they had a problem.

Source: KFF, Claims Denials and Appeals in ACA Marketplace Plans: <https://www.kff.org/private-insurance/issue-brief/claims-denials-and-appeals-in-aca-marketplace-plans/>

Source: CMS, Understanding Your Health Coverage: <https://www.cms.gov/marketplace/consumer-outreach/understanding-your-health-coverage>

Put those together and a picture emerges: insurance companies deny a lot of claims. Almost nobody pushes back. When people do push back, a real share of them win. And most of the people who don't appeal simply didn't know they could, or didn't know how.

That's not a system where fighting is hopeless. It's a system where fighting is unusually effective, mostly because so few people do it.

Why your letter is the authority, not us

You'll notice this guide almost never tells you "you have this many days" or "you have this right," flat out. That's on purpose. Appeal rules differ by the kind of plan you have, by your state, and sometimes by the year. Your letter was written for your specific plan and your specific claim.

When something you read online, including in this guide, disagrees with your letter, trust your letter. If you're ever unsure, call the number printed on it and ask directly.

Where we do point you to a number, like a federal minimum, we'll tell you exactly where it comes from and link you to the source, so you can check it yourself.

What's probably in your letter

Denial letters aren't all identical, but for many plans, federal rules require insurers to include certain things. Use this as a checklist to scan your letter for, not a guarantee of exactly what you'll find, since your plan type changes some of the details.

- A claim or reference number
- The specific reason your claim was denied, often shown as a short code plus a description
- A section usually titled something like "Your Appeal Rights" or "How to Appeal"
- A stated deadline for filing your appeal
- Contact information for who to call with questions
- A note about your right to request the specific diagnosis and treatment codes used, free of charge, if they weren't already included

Source: 45 CFR § 147.136, the federal regulation on adverse benefit determination notices: <https://www.ecfr.gov/current/title-45/subtitle-A/subchapter-B/part-147/section-147.136>

This particular rule applies most directly to Marketplace and job-based insured plans. If you have Medicare, Medicaid, or a self-funded employer plan, the exact list can look a little different. The full course helps you sort out which rules apply to you.

If you can't find your letter

No letter in front of you right now? You still have options.

- Log into your insurance company's member portal. Denial letters, sometimes labeled an "Explanation of Benefits" or a "Notice of Adverse Benefit Determination," are often archived there.
- Call the member services number on the back of your insurance card and ask them to resend it.
- Ask for a copy in writing, not just a verbal explanation. You'll want it on paper for the rest of this process.

A script for calling your insurer

If picking up the phone feels awkward, here's something you can read almost word for word. Fill in your own details where marked.

"Hi, my name is [YOUR NAME]. My member ID is [MEMBER ID NUMBER].

I received a claim denial and I do not have a copy of the full letter.

Can you mail or email me a copy of the denial notice, along with the specific diagnosis and treatment codes you used and the reason for the denial?

| I would also like to know the exact deadline for filing an appeal on this claim."

Write down the name of the person you spoke with, the date, and anything they tell you. You'll want this for your records when you build your evidence file.

DO THIS NOW

1. Find your denial letter. Check your mail, email, and your insurance company's online member portal.
2. Locate your claim number and the stated reason for denial.
3. Find the section about appeal rights (often called "Your Appeal Rights" or "How to Appeal") and note anything it says about a deadline.
4. If you can't find the letter, call the number on your insurance card and use the script above to request a copy.
5. Keep the letter somewhere you can find it again. You'll come back to it at every step that follows.

When you're ready for the full playbook

This free guide is Module 0 of the full Let's Appeal course. The full course continues from here with seven more modules that walk you through the entire appeal, step by step: finding your real deadline, identifying your plan type and which rules apply to you, building your evidence file, writing an appeal letter that responds point by point to your own denial, submitting and tracking it, taking a second denial to external review, and handling urgent situations when you can't wait.

Students in the full course also get Ask the Guide, an AI tutor trained on every module. When you're stuck at 11 PM with your letter in one hand and a half-written appeal in the other, you can paste in the part you're wrestling with and talk it through. It's like having a study partner who has already read your letter with you.

You'll find the full course at letsappeal.com.

Educational information only, not legal, medical, or insurance advice. Always confirm details against your own plan documents and denial letter.